

Contemporaneous meeting notes for use with other resources in preparation of draft minutes
MEMBERS – PERSONS appearing – BRIEF DESCRIPTION – DECISIONS. RSA 91-A:2.

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, May 28, 2025, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne - Absent

Ward II Councilor Brian Zutter

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Hayden

Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau

At-Large Councilor William Greenrose

At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway

At-Large Councilor William Limoges

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski

Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Nancy Bates, Finance Director/Interim City Manager

Brent Wilmot, Chief of Police/Interim City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

Mayor Girard removed New Business Item Resolution 2025-54 Automated Weather Observing System until the June 11, 2025, Council Meeting.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Greenrose to suspend council rules to add two items to the agenda.

Roll Call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

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Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Assistant Mayor Matteau added two new items, item E Motion to Indemnify, and item F. Overspending a line-item discussion.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Zutter to accept the minutes of the May 7, 2025, City Council meeting.

Councilor Hemingway stated the General Fund vote should be 9-0. All were in favor of the change.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept the minutes of the May 14, 2025, City Council meeting.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

MAYOR'S NOTES

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Mayor Girard presented the Stevens Alumni Proclamation

Arrowhead is hosing enduro racing this weekend.

Kiwanis Club of Claremont is hosting their annual Kids Fishing Derby on Saturday June 7 at Corbin Bridge in Newport. Registration at 8am, fishing beginning 9am to 11am, open for ages 4-15.

Claremont Parks and Recreation will be hosting a movie night on the green, June 7th at 8pm, and thanked Loves Bedding for sponsoring the event.

The Well Collaborative at 72 Pleasant Street will be hosting a small business skills at 6pm on Monday June 9th on effective email and newsletter marketing.

Councilor Limoges reported the Wall That Heals will arrive on 24th, and trying to get the businesses along Washington Street to come out during the arrival, still looking for volunteers, the Wall officially opens on the 26th. There will be a welcoming home ceremony, and Counseling from the VA.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Director Bates noted 17 Water Street is up for sale and the City has and is continuing to accept proposals.

The 2025 first half Tax Warrant has been generated; the tax bill will be going out shortly.

The City is actively recruiting for a Planning and Development Director.

In response to many Council inquiries there was a meeting held with the Co-Interim City Managers, the Project Manager, and Department of Public Works on how the City can better monitor projects, and will be developing standard operating procedures with clear responsibilities.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Chuck Egbert, Ward III, is asking Council to look into the never-ending use of the speedway. Mr. Egbert has concerns that there are races happening 6 days in one week.

Colleen Hayes, Ward III representing the Board of the West Claremont Center for Music and Arts about to kick off the Summer Series and personally invited Council and the public to join the events.

OLD BUSINESS

Resolution 2025-51 Safe Streets and Roads Grant Match – Public Hearing

Director Bates noted this was a county grant that was applied for and the City committed to give \$30,000 for a matching grant, there is a local match expendable trust fund.

A motion was made by Councilor Hemingway and seconded by Councilor Koloski to Accept resolution 2025-51.

Councilor Hemingway read Resolution 2025-51 into the record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

NEW BUSINESS

Ordinance 639 Non-Union Employee Merit Scale Attachment C Adjustment First Reading

Councilor Koloski recused himself due to being an on-call firefighter.

Director Thibodeau presented the non-union Merit scale adjustment and noted it was a 2% increase for the merit scale to remain fair and competitive.

Councilor Greenrose asked what the total impact is, Director Bates stated not having the exact breakdown of the numbers but the increase is reflected in the proposed budget.

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A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Zutter to pass Ordinance 639 to a second reading on the June 11th, 2025, Council Meeting.

Assistant Mayor Matteau read the Explanation of proposed action into the record.

Voice vote:

Koloski – recused

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 7-0

Charter Amendment Vote – Residency Clause for City Manager

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted the Council had proposed this change a few years ago and it failed, but it's important to have this flexibility to find a good candidate. Assistant Mayor Matteau would love to see the next City Manager live in Claremont but that just may not work.

Councilor Hemingway would highly encourage a City Manager to be within City limits. There are a lot of meetings and functions that they would need to attend.

Councilor Greenrose agrees with those points, and noted if its someone across the country they have to re-locate anyway, or there may be a great candidate 10 miles out of the City, thinks this is for getting the largest pool of the most qualified candidates.

Councilor Limoges stated not wanting someone always working from home.

Mayor Girard mentioned adding in the contract this would be an in-person position, and understands some citizens have concerns but hope people will take time to consider this option as it would open a larger pool of candidates.

Motion to Produce Report for City Clerk and State Officials
Identifying Proposed Amendment to the City's Charter

The Claremont City Council hereby submits a proposed amendment to the City Charter that seeks to alter Part I, Article III, Section 27 in order to remove the residency requirement for any potential hire for City Manager. The amendment also proposes to eliminate all pronouns provided within same. These Council-approved changes, associated with this Charter amendment, are provided below:

PROPOSED AMENDMENT TO CITY CHARTER:

Part I, Article III, Section 27 - Qualifications

Current Version

• **27. - Qualifications.**

The manager shall be chosen solely on the basis of his/her executive and administrative qualifications, but he/she need not be a resident of the City or state at the time of his/her appointment. During his/her tenure of office, he/she shall reside within the City. To avoid a conflict of interest, no person who has within two (2) years been elected by popular vote to any office in the City of Claremont shall be chosen manager.

Proposed Amendment to Section 27: The sentence “During his/her tenure of office, he/she shall reside within the City.” will be removed from the Charter. The pronouns will also be removed from this particular provision in the Charter.

• **27. - Qualifications.**

—The manager shall be chosen solely on the basis of ~~his/her~~ executive and administrative qualifications, but ~~he/she~~ need not be a resident of the City or state at the time of ~~his/her~~

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appointment. ~~During his/her tenure of office, he/she shall reside within the city.~~ To avoid a conflict of interest, no person who has within two (2) years been elected by popular vote to any office in the City of Claremont shall be chosen manager.

New Version with Amendment:

- **27. - Qualifications.**

The manager shall be chosen solely on the basis of executive and administrative qualifications, but need not be a resident of the City or state at the time of appointment. To avoid a conflict of interest, no person who has within two (2) years been elected by popular vote to any office in the city of Claremont shall be chosen manager.

* * *

The Claremont City Council's approval of this Motion shall constitute the "report" in accordance with N.H. RSA §49-B:5. The Council also orders as well as authorizes the City Manager or designees to submit this report to the City Clerk, the N.H. Secretary of State, N.H. Attorney General's Office and the Commissioner of the N.H. Department of Revenue Administration pursuant to N.H. RSA §49-B:5.

A motion was made by Councilor Hayden and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept Motion to Produce Report for City Clerk and State Officials Identifying Proposed Amendment to the City's Charter.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

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Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Councilor Koloski mentioned not wanting to lose sight on education to the public for both charter amendment items.

Budget

Outside Agency Requests

Southwest Community Services, Sullivan County Humane Society, Meals on Wheels all had representatives and presented their requests to the City Council. The Claremont Soup Kitchen was represented by a Volunteer, Cathy Parks.

Southwest Community Services requested \$30,000. The Sullivan Humane Society requested \$11,000, Meals on Wheels requested \$10,000 and the Soup Kitchen had a written letter of request for \$25,000.

Councilor Hemingway noted it was a tough year and would suggest cutting some of these funds.

Councilor Koloski noted there has never been a “good” year, and Councilor Hayden made a good point about our most vulnerable gets hits the most. Councilor Koloski raised an issue with giving \$9,000 for Arrowhead, but found \$8500 for the Wall that Heals, and clarified he has no problem with this but a problem with pulling the rug from these agencies. Councilor Koloski stated he interacts with a lot of these individuals that rely on these services and wants to do the right thing.

Mayor Girard noted The Wall That Heals money did not come from general fund.

Councilor Hemingway understands what Koloski is saying, and doesn’t feel good about cutting, but noted if the money can be found elsewhere that’s something he would be willing to look at and suggested setting up a fund for these organizations, so the Council doesn’t have to come up with so much money every year. However, it is a tough year with several increases to taxes and suggested this needs to be looked at. Councilor Hemingway stated it may be hurting the lower income community and feels bad about that.

Assistant Mayor Matteau agrees with Councilor Koloski these programs are valuable noting this money is also leveraging more money from grants, the people who will be effected by this cut are people who already have nothing and suggested the following to get to about \$50,000 which in total was given last year to outside agency requests:

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Soup Kitchen \$10,000

Meals on Wheels \$10,000

Southwest Community Services – Transit \$20,000

Humane Society \$9,000

Councilor Hayden disagreed and stated the Council can't cut the underserved community as they have nothing left to cut, if we don't pay through this small amount, we will be paying for homelessness, and noted the Council isn't paying for paychecks, but instead supporting volunteers.

Without a proper presentation Councilor Hayden was comfortable proposing \$10,000 to the Soup Kitchen, \$10,000 for Meals on Wheels, and stated for Southwest we are trying to support these people, and do better on the welfare line, if these services are cut we will not do better on welfare, and noted It's our due diligence as a government to support our whole population and that includes taking care of the citizens in the most need and not cutting those fundings. Councilor Hayden does not think the Council should cut the requested \$30,000 from Southwest Services, and with cutting the soup kitchen down to \$10,000 Suggested maybe \$3600 for the spay and neuter program, and stated it was difficult to evaluate a cat's life to a human's life.

Councilor Zutter stated this is tough, it hits home to a lot of people and noted it's not easy to do the right thing, but is in support of where these are, with maybe minor adjustments.

Councilor Limoges agrees with Assistant Mayor Matteau

Councilor Greenrose agrees the City needs to be fiscally prudent, those who have the least are getting hit the most and stated being comfortable with the number that the director put in this budget.

Mayor Girard asked if the Council considered the \$9,000 for Arrowhead and is in support of what Assistant Mayor Matteau suggested bringing the total to \$54,000.

Humane Society \$5,000

Southwest Community Services – Transit - \$20,000

Arrowhead \$9,000

Meals on Wheels \$10,000

Soup Kitchen \$10,000

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to tentatively approve the Outside Agency Budget for a total of \$54,000.

Councilor Koloski clarified there will be final approval of these budgets and encourages the public to come and give feedback.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

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Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – no

Girard – yes

Motion carried 7-1

Policy/Administration

Director Bates presented the 411 Budget and noted it includes the City Manager's office and the HR office.

Regular pay was increased for the City Manager salary to be competitive in the market , and a part time HR assistant.

A lot of this budget to was moved to the 418 budget which is the technology budget, CCTV pass-through and some software.

Councilor Koloski questioned the property maintenance and repair line, Director Bates noted there were no other notes so is unsure of what the motivation for this line was.

By consensus the Council agrees to cut the repair line by \$15,000.

Mayor Girard will support the additional Human Resource position and has heard this from the last three HR managers.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Zutter to Tentative Approval for \$758,320.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Assessing

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Mayor Girard noted the consulting services has stayed the same for the third consecutive year. Mayor Girard asked about the Transfer to capital reserve to set money aside for the 5 year re-evaluation and what will we have if we put this money away, Director Bates stated about \$100,000.

A motion was made by Councilor Greenrose and seconded by Councilor Limoges to tentatively approve the Assessing Budget for \$290,721.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Planning and Development

Director Bates presented the Planning and Development Budget and noted the significant changes were the removal of the Assistant Director Position , and the benefits that go with it. Also stating there were no notes left with this budget so she will try to answer questions appropriately.

Councilor Hemingway asked what downtown development was, Director Bates noted this was downtown beautification.

Mayor Girard asked to cut the consulting service line for UVLSRC.

Director Bates would want input from City Planner Ford before making this cut.

Mayor Girard had concerns with Marketing and Website.

Director Bates asked the Council to keep in mind the City just hired a Business Development Specialist. Councilor Zutter stated \$15,000 was too high for a website.

Mayor Girard would like to see the marketing line at \$30,000 and the website at \$5,000, consulting UVLSRC drop by \$5,000 to make it \$16,509. Which would be about \$20,000 savings on this budget.

Councilor Hayden noted the website is the first interaction with the City and doesn't think this needs to be cut.

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Councilor Koloski does not agree with cutting this budget , seeing a lot of activity, and the selling of this City begins with this office.

Assistant Mayor Matteau stated last year the Council approved a budget with a \$100,000 position, now its removed and feels there is some wiggle room, noting a \$20,000 cut is reasonable.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Hemingway to Tentatively approve the Planning and Development Budget to \$874,208.

Roll call:

Koloski – no

Greenrose – no

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – no

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – no

Girard – yes

Motion Failed – 4-4

Budget to be brought back at another meeting.

Information Technology

Director Bates noted the changes are from franchise fees that were previously in the 411-budget and transferring money from capital reserve for IT infrastructure.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Greenrose to tentatively approve the Information Technology Budget revenue of \$245,000 and appropriations of \$720,384.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

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Finance

Director Bates noted changes such as pulling IT and software out of this budget and into the IT budget, not a significant change otherwise.

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively approve the Finance Budget for \$760,865.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Elections

Director Bates stated the voting machines need to be replaced, replacing the three with new technology and has put money aside in Capital Reserves for this and funding from state. Pole pads will be replaced from paper to electronic and its directly linked to the state system, this budget is going down but also purchasing a lot of new equipment.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Greenrose to tentatively approve the the election budget for \$21,730.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Debt Service

Director Bates explained these are scheduled loan payments for FY26.

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A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to tentatively approve the Debt Service Budget for **\$845,085**.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Motion for indemnification

Director Bates explained there is a lawsuit against city employees and this would indemnify them so our city attorney can represent them in the lawsuit.

Motion to Authorize Indemnification of City of Claremont Officers, Employees and Appointees

The Claremont City Council, pursuant to RSA 31:105 and RSA 31:106, agrees to indemnify and save harmless any person elected, appointed or employed by it and any member or officer of its governing board, administrative staff or agencies, including but not limited to city councilors, city manager, representatives to commissions, municipal boards and committees, health officers and overseers of public welfare, of and from personal financial loss and expense, including reasonable legal fees and costs, if any, arising out of any claim, demand, suit or judgment by reason of negligence or other act resulting in accidental injury to a person or accidental damage to or destruction of property, as well as any such personal financial loss and expense, including reasonable legal fees and costs, if any, arising out of any claim, demand, suit or judgment by reason of any act or omission constituting a violation of the civil rights of an employee or any other person under any federal law if such act or omission was not committed with malice. Any such indemnification shall apply only if the indemnified person was acting within the scope of employment or office at the time

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of the accident resulting in the injury, damage or destruction and/or if the indemnified person was acting within the scope of employment or office at the time of such act or omission.

A motion was made by Councilor Hemingway and seconded by Councilor Zutter to Authorize Indemnification of City of Claremont Officers, Employees and Appointees.

Roll Call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Overspending Line-Item Discussion

Director Bates asked how the City should pay for the contract pay out for the former City Manager and recommends using the Retirement/Severance Expendable Trust Fund, there is approximately \$680,000 in this account currently.

By consensus Council agrees to have a resolution brought back to the next Council meeting using the Retirement/Severance Expendable Trust Fund for the former City Manager's payout.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Councilor Koloski reported for the Arts Committee that it will be self-funded through fundraising efforts.

Councilor Greenrose reported the Energy Advisory had their first meeting with lots of action items, also reviewing Chapter 4 of the master plan.

Assistant Mayor Matteau reported Planning met last night and approved an additional housing unit on School Street and discussed self-storage definitions.

Mayor Girard reported the CDA is still handling maintenance issues.

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FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Councilor Hayden would like an update on Water Street proposals.

Assistant Mayor Matteau wants to revisit Class 6 roads and the proper mechanism to adopt the provisions of the State RSA.

Councilor Hemingway would like a discussion and update on the CDA.

Councilor Koloski would like a full legal update for pending lawsuits and to lower legal services.

Councilor Koloski mentioned the Licensing Boards needs a citizen third member.

Councilor Hayden would like Motor Sports Speedway information.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:06 p.m., a motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Zutter to adjourn.

Voice Vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose – yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro

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Clerk to the Council

DRAFT